

# COLOR CLUES

## MICRORAPTOR

In 2012, paleontologists made an exciting discovery while examining this excellently preserved fossil in northeastern China. This specimen of *Microraptor* was in such good condition that they were able to identify and even study pigments on soft tissues, such as feathers. This little theropod was closely related to modern birds, had four feathered “wings,” and may have been capable of powered flight. The stomach area of one *Microraptor* fossil contained the fossil of another small animal, later identified as a new species of prehistoric lizard. This discovery also showed that *Microraptor* probably swallowed prey whole and head first, just as modern carnivorous birds do.

### AT A GLANCE

- **YEAR OF RESEARCH** 2012
- **PLACE** China
- **STUDIED BY** Quanguo Li and team
- **LIVED** 125–120 MYA



### UV DISCOVERIES

One of the techniques used to study *Microraptor*'s feathers involved shining ultraviolet (UV) light on the fossil. Certain parts of it appeared fluorescent under UV light (as seen here), which allowed scientists to study the extent and arrangement of fossilized soft tissue, such as feathers.

